

AFL Tactical Drill Database:

Comprehensive Edition

1. AFL Inside 50 Entry Drill

Goal: Promote movement to find space in the forward line and execute precise kicks for scoring opportunities.

Phase of the Game: Attack | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Place a cone 15 m from goal (Position A).
- Place a cone on the 50 m line directly out from goal (Position B).
- Split the group into two even teams (Attackers and Defenders).
- One attacker and one defender start at Position B; the attacker holds the football.
- Remaining pairs start at Position A.

Execution:

- On the coach's whistle, the attacker at Position B pushes back off the mark.
- Attackers at Position A work together to create space and help a teammate get free.
- The attacker with the football finds the best option and kicks to a teammate for a mark and set shot on goal.
- Defenders attempt to stop the attack and clear the ball outside the 50 m arc.
- Rotate roles after each attempt.

Coaching Points:

- Observe attackers adjusting their movement to create genuine space.
- Focus on the decision-making process for the player with the ball.
- Encourage communication and teamwork within the forward line.

CHANGE IT Tip: Adjust the distance between cones or limit the number of touches allowed to increase the pressure and challenge the skill level.

2. AFL 3v1 Clearing Kick Drill

Goal: Promote support play when close to goal to create scoring opportunities.

Phase of the Game: Attack | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Set up a 10 m by 10 m diamond with four cones positioned 40 m from goal.
- Divide the group into three attackers and one defender (wearing a bib).
- Defender starts at Position A; attackers start at Positions B, C, and D.

Execution:

- Defender handballs to the attacker at Position C to begin the drill.
- Attackers handball to each other to progress the ball past the defender.
- Once attackers are clear of the defender and in open space, the player with the ball takes a shot at goal.
- Players retrieve the ball and return to starting positions.
- Rotate roles so everyone acts as both attacker and defender.

Coaching Points:

- Observe attackers moving into positions to receive the ball and set up for a shot at goal.
- Focus on teamwork and ball movement to evade the defender.

CHANGE IT Tip: Reduce the size of the diamond to 8 m by 8 m to increase pressure and force quicker decision-making.

3. AFL Midfield Transition Drill

Goal: Teach midfielders the principles of outnumbering in the forward and back lines.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 6

Setup:

- Set up a field 40 m wide by 60 m long with goals at each end.
- Place lines of cones 20 m from each goal line to create three specific zones.
- Split players into two even teams (one team in bibs).
- Place an even number of players in each zone; designate midfield players as "floaters."

Execution:

- Start with a ball-up in the center; teams compete to win the ball.
- Play with normal football rules; players must stay in their designated zones.
- "Floater" midfielders are free to move anywhere on the field to provide support.
- After a goal, restart with a ball-up in the center.
- Rotate player roles to ensure everyone experiences the midfield and floater positions.

Coaching Points:

- Encourage floaters to identify when and where to provide numerical support.
- Focus on effective decision-making when transitioning between defensive and forward zones.

CHANGE IT Tip: Restrict the number of possessions allowed before a mandatory pass to encourage faster ball movement and transition play.

4. AFL Handball Grid Drill

Goal: Teach principles of support and maintaining possession in tight situations.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Set up a 5 m by 5 m square using four cones.
- Organize a small group (3-5 players) into attackers and one defender (wearing a bib).
- One attacker begins with the ball.

Execution:

- On the coach's whistle, attackers move the ball around the square using handballs only.
- Defender applies pressure, attempting to slow down the attackers and cause a turnover.
- After a set time, rotate roles so everyone experiences both attacking and defending.

Coaching Points:

- Watch for receiving players identifying and moving into open space.

- Observe the ball carrier attempting different ways to move the ball and find a teammate.

CHANGE IT Tip: Reduce the grid size further or limit the number of handballs allowed in a sequence to increase pressure.

5. Essential AFL Fundamentals

Goal: Provide players with the opportunity to practice different game skills with high repetition.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 4

Setup:

- Set up a 20 m by 20 m space per pair of players.
- Players work in pairs, each with a football.
- Players begin 2 m apart and progress to 20 m apart during activities.

Execution:

- Set up multiple paired activities covering handballing, ball handling, and kicking.
- Coaches regularly modify activities to challenge natural techniques and encourage problem-solving.
- Encourage skill variation alongside repetition.

Coaching Points:

- Focus on challenging the natural technique of each fundamental skill.
- Encourage players to create solutions when executing skills under different variables.

CHANGE IT Tip: Introduce movement constraints or target-based challenges for kicks and handballs to add game-like pressure.

6. AFL Kick and Mark Drill

Goal: Improve kicking accuracy and marking consistency under pressure.

Phase of the Game: Attack | **Target Age Group:** Level 4

Setup:

- Set up two lines of cones, 20 m apart, facing each other.
- Place a small group of players at each end, with one ball per pair.

Execution:

- Players kick the ball to their partner on the opposite side.
- The partner focuses on moving to meet the ball and executing a clean mark.
- After a set number of repetitions, players swap lines or switch to a different kicking style (e.g., drop punt, banana kick).
- Introduce a defender in the middle to create pressure once players are proficient.

Coaching Points:

- Emphasize the importance of the lead and the follow-through in kicking.
- Watch for clean handling and eyes on the ball during the mark.

CHANGE IT Tip: Reduce the gap between players to 10 m to force faster decision-making and quicker disposal.

7. AFL Lateral Movement and Disposal Drill

Goal: Enhance agility, decision-making, and disposal efficiency under lateral pressure.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 6

Setup:

- Set up three cones in a straight line, 5 m apart.
- Place a player at each end cone and a defender in the middle.
- Start with the ball at one end cone.

Execution:

- The player with the ball moves laterally toward the center, evading the defender.
- The player then disposes of the ball (handball or kick) to the teammate at the opposite end cone.
- The defender attempts to intercept or put pressure on the disposal.
- Rotate roles after each rep to ensure all players practice evading and defending.

Coaching Points:

- Focus on explosive lateral steps to create space.

- Keep the head up while moving to scan for the teammate.
- Ensure disposal technique is clean even when fatigued.

CHANGE IT Tip: Add a second defender to the middle to increase the difficulty of finding the passing lane.

8. AFL Shadow Defensive Drill

Goal: Improve defensive positioning, closing speed, and awareness of the opponent's movement.

Phase of the Game: Defence | **Target Age Group:** Level 6

Setup:

- Set up a 10 m by 10 m grid.
- Pair up players, with one acting as the attacker and one as the defender (wearing a bib).
- Attackers start at one side of the grid.

Execution:

- On the coach's signal, the attacker moves freely within the grid, changing direction and pace.
- The defender must maintain a "shadow" position, staying close to the attacker without making contact.
- Focus on keeping the eyes on the attacker's hips and maintaining an athletic stance.
- After 30 seconds, swap roles.

Coaching Points:

- Emphasize staying in the "back pocket" of the attacker.
- Encourage quick feet and adjustment of body position during sharp turns.
- Ensure the defender maintains a balanced, low center of gravity.

CHANGE IT Tip: Introduce a ball for the attacker to carry, requiring the defender to focus on body positioning rather than just intercepting the ball.

9. AFL Goal-Face Pressure Drill

Goal: Simulate match-day pressure and improve goal-kicking accuracy under defensive intensity.

Phase of the Game: Attack | **Target Age Group:** Level 6

Setup:

- Set up a goal-kicking corridor 20 m from goal.
- Place a small group of attackers at the 50 m line and a designated defender near the goal-face.
- Attackers have a ball and prepare to run into the goal-kicking corridor.

Execution:

- The attacker receives a handball on the move and enters the goal-kicking corridor.
- The defender applies immediate pressure, forcing the attacker to execute a quick, clean set shot.
- Attackers must maintain composure and focus on goal-kicking technique while under physical presence.
- Rotate roles after each attempt.

Coaching Points:

- Focus on keeping the head still and eyes on the drop zone during the kick.
- Emphasize the importance of the approach run and maintaining balance through the kick.
- Encourage the defender to apply realistic, legal pressure without fouling.

CHANGE IT Tip: Add a second defender to force the attacker to make a quick decision between taking a shot or passing to a teammate in a better position.

10. AFL Peripheral Vision Kicking Drill

Goal: Improve awareness of teammates and opponents while executing precise kicks under spatial pressure.

Phase of the Game: Attack | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Set up a 10 m by 10 m diamond with a cone in the center.

- Place four attackers at the outer cones and one "kicker" at the center cone.
- Assign one defender to move between the outer cones.

Execution:

- The central kicker must scan the field to identify which outer attacker is open.
- On the coach's call, the kicker executes a kick to the open target.
- The defender attempts to intercept or block the passing lanes.
- Rotate the kicker and defender after every five attempts.

Coaching Points:

- Emphasize scanning the field **before** receiving the ball.
- Focus on body positioning to disguise the intended target.
- Encourage quick, accurate disposal once the target is identified.

CHANGE IT Tip: Add a second defender to the diamond to force the kicker to look for the "next best" option under higher congestion.

11. AFL Clean Hands & Rapid Handball Drill

Goal: Develop quick decision-making and precise handball skills in congested situations.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Set up a 5 m by 5 m grid with one player in each corner and one player in the center.
- The center player begins with the ball.

Execution:

- The center player handballs to a corner player, who immediately returns the handball.
- The center player then rotates to face another corner player and repeats the exchange.
- Continue this pattern for a set time, focusing on receiving and delivering under pressure.
- Rotate the center player so everyone practices distributing from the middle.

Coaching Points:

- Focus on receiving the ball at the chest and transferring to the hip for a quick handball.
- Emphasize the "target" hand and following through to ensure accuracy.
- Keep the feet moving to maintain balance and quick reactions.

CHANGE IT Tip: Add a defender into the grid to pressure the center player, forcing them to find the "open" target while under physical scrutiny.

12. AFL Ground Ball & Transition Drill

Goal: Improve ball handling at ground level and immediate transition into attack.

Phase of the Game: Contest | **Target Age Group:** Level 5

Setup:

- Set up two cones 10 m apart, with a ball placed in the middle.
- Divide players into two lines, one behind each cone.
- Assign one player as the "chaser" and one as the "attacker."

Execution:

- On the coach's whistle, both players sprint to the ball.
- The attacker aims to secure the ground ball cleanly and transition to a designated target area.
- The chaser applies pressure to force a fumble or contest the ball.
- Rotate roles after each attempt.

Coaching Points:

- Emphasize the "soft hands" technique when approaching the ground ball.
- Focus on keeping the eyes on the ball until it is secured.
- Encourage an immediate look up to identify the next target after winning possession.

CHANGE IT Tip: Add an extra defender to create a 2v1 situation, increasing the pressure to secure the ball and find an outlet pass.